Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

February 4, 2002

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 02S32 – 2002 Model Year Ranger manual transmission Trucks equipped with the FX4 package – Rear Axle Differential

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving the rear axle differential on 2002 Model Year Ford Ranger manual transmission trucks equipped with the FX4 package. These vehicles were built from May 3, 2001 through January 28, 2002.

- Number of Vehicles Involved – Approximately 1,178 vehicles (1,096 in the United States and federalized territories, 82 in Canada).

- Affect on Vehicle Operation -- The rear axle differential case may fracture under a high torque event such as when customers accelerate rapidly from a stop or when a spinning tire suddenly gains traction. The vehicle may exhibit a clunk or grinding noise indicating a possible rear axle differential fracture. Differential fractures may potentially result in wheel lock-up. There are no known accidents, fires or injuries attributed to this condition.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will replace the rear axle assembly in the affected vehicles.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

Attachment
02S32 5d/kek

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
02S32 – 2002 MODEL YEAR FORD RANGER FX4 WITH MANUAL TRANSMISSIONS

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

All 2002 Model Year Ford Ranger manual transmission trucks equipped with the FX4 package built at the Edison and Twin Cities Assembly Plants from May 3, 2001 through January 28, 2002 are affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 1,096 manual transmission trucks equipped with the FX4 package.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

All of the involved vehicles have differential cases with the condition described below. However, not all of these vehicles would be expected to experience a case fracture; only those that are subjected to particularly high torque events would be expected to fracture.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

The rear axle differential case may fracture under a high torque event such as when customers accelerate rapidly from a stop or when a spinning tire suddenly gains traction. The vehicle may exhibit a clunk or grinding noise indicating a possible rear axle differential fracture. Differential fractures may potentially result in wheel lock-up.

The supplier of the differential case implemented a change to the design, which increased the 'window' size in the casting. The change to the casting results in insufficient strength to withstand the impact loading delivered by the manual transmission application to the rear axle. Ford was not made aware of the casting change until after the reports of fractures on vehicles in service.

Ford is aware of three reports of rear axle differential lockup resulting from this condition. There are no known accidents, fires or injuries attributed to this condition.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first became aware of this condition on January 7, 2002, with reports of two rear axle issues on 2002 Ranger FX4's equipped with manual transmissions. A third vehicle exhibited this condition during pre-delivery preparation within the same time period. Ford immediately initiated a Stop Ship from the affected assembly plants.

Visteon, the supplier of the axle assemblies, retrieved the axles. Teardown confirmed the differential cases had fractured. Comparison of production and prototype differential cases highlighted differences in the 'window' area of the casting. It was determined that the supplier of the casting implemented a change to the design, which increased the 'window' size in the casting. The change to the casting results in insufficient strength to withstand the impact loading delivered by the manual transmission application to the rear axle.

There are no known accidents, fires or injuries attributed to this condition.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford has notified dealers to not demonstrate or deliver the affected vehicles until the rear axle assembly is replaced. Ford will notify owners of record of the affected vehicles twice for this recall. The first notification will be an awareness owner letter, which will be sent in the week of February 11, 2002 informing the owner of the condition and providing driving suggestions to minimize the likelihood of initiating the condition. The owner letter will also provide estimated timing for the availability of parts to repair vehicles and offer a dealer inspection of the rear differential prior to parts availability if the customer so chooses. A second owner notification will begin in early April informing owners to return vehicles to dealers to have the rear axle assembly replaced.

There will be no charge to owners for this service.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning the subject matter of this action. A copy of the Notification letters to dealers and owners from Ford will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 02S32 to this action.